

The Travis Panorama

As the Civil War drew to its close, Union veterans of Major General William S. Rosecrans's Army of the Cumberland commissioned artist William (Bill) D. T. Travis to commemorate their campaigns in a massive painted "panorama," 528ft (161m) long.

Attached to the Union army as a staff artist working for two illustrated news weeklies, Travis had already observed and sketched the scenes he would now be painting. In all, his creation consisted of 33 panels, each measuring 16x8ft (4.9x2.4m) and telling a different part of the story of the Army of the Cumberland. The panels were painted onto coarse cotton for flexibility and then stitched together in chronological order to form a single, vast canvas—an example of the "moving panoramas" that were a popular entertainment at the time. For public viewing, the panorama was set up on a stage between two spools, then hand-cranked slowly from one side of the stage to the other. The series of sequential images memorialized the army's progress from October 1862 to the end of 1863. The Panorama depicts bloody engagements that Travis himself had witnessed, from the Battle of Perryville in Kentucky through the defeat at Chickamauga, and ending with the breaking of Braxton Bragg's Confederate army at Missionary Ridge. Travis also chronicled some of the finer details of army life, including soldiers leaving home and loved ones to go to war, foraging for food, and establishing supply lines. From 1865 to 1871 Travis, with his brother James, took the panorama on a tour of the Midwest, where many Army of the Cumberland veterans were now living. Handling the equipment themselves in churches and lecture halls, one brother would crank the images across the stage while the other narrated the events of the campaigns to the audience. General Rosecrans was well satisfied with the result. He stated that Bill Travis had created one of the "great conceptions of struggles on the battlefield."



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